the Rajasthan civic poll result marked the beginning of a broader trend or was merely an aberration.

Surjewala argues that the Congress itself is a far more complicated organisation, with competing ideological strands and entrenched interests that do not always move with Rahul. Yet he insists the cadre is increasingly aligned with Rahul, pointing to the turnout at youth programmes in Prayagraj and Kota. "The Congress party is like an elephant. It responds slowly, but when it moves, it does so with enormous force. Even the big cats make way for it."

INTERNAL HICCUPS

One reason the message does not always travel is that Congress-ruled states often behave like independent political republics, absorbed in their own governments, personalities and local equations. News headlines come as frequently from internal wars as from the issues Rahul wants the party to fight on nationally. Karnataka spent the better part of three years consumed by the Siddaramaiah-Shivakumar succession question before the high command forced a transition in late May 2026. In Kerala, the one big assembly prize of 2026, a 10-day deadlock between V.D. Satheesan and K.C. Venugopal produced protests outside Kerala House in Delhi, followed by a cabinet that was described as an "even-stevens" division between the two camps. In Punjab, the rival factions of PCC chief Amarinder Singh Raja Warring and campaign committee chairman Charanjit Singh Channi clashed at party meetings in August, threatening to upset even the Har Booth Congress Mazboot campaign.

These contradictions also create a credibility problem. Rahul's politics will remain just rhetoric unless Congress state governments become laboratories for it. The Congress had promised back in 2022 to give greater space to younger leaders, women, OBCs, Dalits and Adivasis. Much of that change has yet to become visible on the ground.

Rahul's supporters within the party point towards a dearth of talent. "We simply do not have enough election managers, and the party is unwilling to engage with professionals," says a close associate. But there are signs that things may be changing. In September, Rahul, Priyanka and Venugopal personally interviewed around 130 potential candidates for All India Congress Committee (AICC) secretary posts as part of a review that could replace nearly half of the existing lot. That effort fits into a wider organisational reset. The Sangathan Srijan Abhiyan, launched after the Belagavi session in December 2024, has changed how district presidents are selected. Around 700 district presidents have been appointed, with another 200 to 250 planned. Their average age is around 45 to 50.

CHALLENGES AHEAD

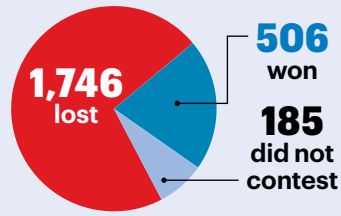
Assembly polls due till June 2029, with Congress figures from the previous election

20 No. of states going to polls

2,437 Assembly seats on offer

3 States ruled by Congress → Karnataka, Telangana, Himachal Pradesh

In the past polls, Congress contested 2,252 seats. Win rate: 22%



MARGIN CALL

Congress in assembly polls after the 2024 general election

11 No. of states that went to polls

3 States where the party is part of government → Kerala (major partner), Jharkhand, Tamil Nadu*

The Congress contested 924 of the total 1,686 seats on offer, won just 171. Win rate: 19%

*Was also part of J&K winning alliance

LITTLE CONSENSUS

The same problem extends to the Opposition INDIA bloc. Rahul has workable personal equations with Akhilesh, Tejashwi Yadav (RJD), M.K. Stalin (DMK), Uddhav Thackeray (Sena-UBT) and Sharad Pawar (NCP-SP). But personal comfort cannot substitute for rules between parties. The INDIA meeting in June exposed grievances over Congress's treatment of the DMK, its competition with the Left and state units that undermine national understandings. CPI(M) leader and ex-Kerala CM Pinarayi Vijayan even alleged that Rahul's approach was "creating a situation where he effectively becomes a facilitator of the BJP's interests".

Tamil Nadu is the most dramatic case. The Congress, which won just five seats, left its old DMK partnership and joined the Vijay-led TVK (Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam) government. Months later, the new allies were competing over the national crown: Congress leaders asserted Rahul's claim as the prime ministerial contender for 2029 while TVK supporters projected Vijay. CPI(M) general secretary M.A. Baby was succinct in his response: "Congress leaders talking about Rahul being the INDIA bloc's prime ministerial candidate is quite premature."

For much of the Congress leader's career, voters were unsure which Rahul they were being offered. That question has largely been answered, for he now has a clearer ideological vocabulary. But can he turn a follower into a voter, a state victory into a national model and personal chemistry into a durable coalition? Until he does, Rahul Gandhi will remain the Opposition's most visible challenger to Modi and the BJP without commanding the political machine that visibility requires. ■